From the sky descended a scourge so great
That courtyard and roof became one from snow?. . .

In the flowing river, there was no more water
In the shining sun, there was no more heat

The cattle outside, whined and howled
Torn to shreds by the wind's murderous blade

For the Firangi horde, already battered by misfortune
The howling of the blizzard and the falling of the snows were a calamity

The soldiers were many and their food was little
Judgement lay behind and death stood before them

To remain was unwise, to escape impossible
No hope of peace, no chance of war[4]

By this stage, the British were also beginning to feel as though they were labouring under the curse of heaven. Even indomitable and ever resolute Lady Sale accepted that things now looked very bad for the besieged troops, writing in her diary with characteristic understatement,

> A dismal Christmas Day, our situation far from cheerful. Lawrence has come in, looking haggard and ten years older from anxiety . . . Naib Sharif paid for the interment of Sir A Burnes's body, but it was never buried; and part of it, cut into many pieces, is still hanging on the trees in his garden. [Now] the Envoy's head is kept in a *bhoosa* bag in the chouk: and Akbar says he will send it to Bokhara to show the King there how he has seized the Firangis here, and what he means to do with them . . . Whether we go by treaty or not, I fear but few of us will live to reach the provinces . . .[5]

She added that while selecting what property she should carry with her on the retreat, she had found a copy of Thomas Campbell's *Poems*,

> which opened at *Hohenlinden*; one verse of which haunted me day and night:
>
> *Few, few shall part where many meet,*
> *The snow shall be their winding sheet;*
> *And every turf beneath their feet*
> *Shall be a soldier's sepulchre.*[6]

To make matters worse, the British troops now learned that Macnaghten had been killed while trying to break the terms of the treaty he had signed with